

BHEL-TRSL has bagged an order to make 80 Vande Bharat sleeper train sets by 2029 at an estimated cost of around ₹24,000 crore.

TRSL Deputy MD Prithish Chowdhary says the first prototype of the sleeper train should be ready by May 2025. “We are ramping up our production capacity to 850 passenger coaches annually by FY28,” he tells *Business Today*.

Besides coaches, private players have also made plans to set up units to manufacture components such as forged wheels, brakes, batteries, and transmission systems. At present, some components used in Vande Bharat trains are imported from countries like China, Russia, Brazil, and a few European nations. Plus there exists a huge gap between the demand and availability of forged wheels, also used in Vande Bharat trains, in India. The Railways estimates the demand for wheels to rise to 200,000 per annum by 2026, from around 120,000 in FY23.

“In 2022-23 alone, we imported around 80,000 wheels worth ₹520 crore from China and Russia, while the remaining 40,000 were sourced from Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL). With the induction of more Vande Bharat and semi-high-speed trains, the demand for forged wheels will further rise, making domestic manufacturing capacity essential,” says Chowdhary.

To address this demand, a consortium of TRSL and Ramkrishna Forgings is setting up the country’s first wheel manufacturing facility in Chennai, where the first set of wheels is set to roll out by May 2026. The total capital expenditure for this project is estimated at ₹1,800-2,000 crore, which is being funded through a mix of debt and equity.

With India also planning to export Vande Bharat trains to neighbouring nations, Anwani feels it could provide a fillip to railway component manufacturers. He says that with export orders, there will also be vendor-based requirements, as not all factories producing coaches are likely to manufacture components such as electrical traction, forged wheels, and steel bodies. “This is where the opportunity lies for PLI and if you want to look at exports then your vendor base should be strong,” he says.

SPEED BUMPS

Mani says the thinking behind the manufacture of Vande Bharat rakes was to speed up trains in India. While the rakes were tested at speeds above 180 kmph during trials, they were approved to run at a maximum speed of 160 kmph by the Commission of Railway Safety. But the average travel time of Vande Bharat trains

WHAT’S SPECIAL



VANDE BHARAT TRAINS ARE FITTED WITH KAVACH, SIDE CAMERAS, AND DISASTER LIGHTS



THEY HAVE FASTER ACCELERATION AND SEMI-HIGH-SPEED OPERATION UP TO 160 KMPH



THEY HAVE FULLY-SEALED GANGWAYS FOR FREE PASSENGER MOVEMENT



THEY ARE EQUIPPED WITH AUTOMATIC PLUG DOORS AND CCTVs IN ALL COACHES



THERE IS LEVEL-II SAFETY INTEGRATION CERTIFICATION AND SUPERIOR FLOOD-PROOFING

The Railways is likely to invest ₹7 lakh crore over the next decade to lay 50,000 km of new tracks to modernise its network and boost train speeds

has increased in the past three years, primarily due to speed restrictions on certain track sections for work related to repairs and upgradation. In fact, in response to an RTI petition filed by Madhya Pradesh-based activist Chandra Shekhar Gaur, the railway ministry said that the average speed of Vande Bharat trains had come down to 76.25 kmph in 2023-24 from 84.48 kmph in 2020-21.

Mani says upgrading track infrastructure remains a challenge as the current ones can support trains running at a maximum speed of 130 kmph. “We need to